



**NUMERO UNO: Kumble is the most respected cricketer today** know why so much was made of it," Kumble says from Adelaide.

The Australians have been accused of rough conduct before, but this time it was this man making the charge that had everyone—including Ricky Ponting's stunned team—take note.

This was cricket's Atlas and he was not shrugging. He was frowning.

Kumble at 37, is the oldest man in his team, the oldest man in international cricket. He is India's leading wicket-taker and match-winner. Of India's 93 Test victories overall, Kumble has been at the centre of 42. He survived the ugliness of the Indian dressing rooms of the 1990s, ridicule from all variety of spin meisters and a career-threatening shoulder surgery.

Over 18 years, he has only ever made news on the field and, on his day, he is a looming, fearsome adversary. But to an India punch-drunk on short-term heroes, usually younger and younger batsmen in increasingly brief forms of the game, Kumble has virtually been invisible.

a tone that silences argument. Former Australian coach John Buchanan believes Kumble has been the "key ingredient as to why India have performed the way they have on this tour".

Outside the arena, Kumble's judgement and decision-making have been pitch perfect particularly after Sydney. Whether it was in the tenor of his statements, his decision to drop the charge against Brad Hogg, to scrap the catching agreement with Ponting or even the tone of his columns, Kumble has outpointed Ponting at every step.

Kumble handled the post-Sydney storm with the calm intent of a battleship moving through a tempest. All through the Sydney stand-off, India thanked that it was Kumble—voice modulated, opinion rational, behaviour civil—who was in charge. The more tense things became the more relaxed the man appeared to be. In Perth, his predecessor Sourav Ganguly told BBC, "I thought he should have been captain long ago." Kumble came to captaincy two months ago through a series of quirky circumstances that continued right up to the day the selectors were

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India has had a long look at Anil Kumble and, barring the odd post-match euphoria, looked elsewhere. But through the crucible of this Australia tour, it is as if India is seeing him—and his qualities—for the first time. He has spoken often of the urge to excel, the drive to win from anywhere, but it is as if India is finally listening to that bass voice, wondering if their ears had been on vacation all this while. To *Sydney Morning Herald* columnist Peter Roebuck a brief fortnight shepherding his team from crises to victory in Australia has made Kumble, "the No. 1 figure in the game today—like Steve Waugh was in his time".

On the field Kumble has led with increasing authority, pushing his team to improved performances. Perth has surprised many but not the Indian captain himself. "India always compete with Australia because we are a good side, we love the challenge," he says in

making their final choice.

At the meeting, four out of five selectors leaned in favour of old skipper M.S. Dhoni taking over the Test team. With Australia looming, central zone selector Sanjay Jagdale listed the reasons why the leg spinner would be the better candidate and asked his colleagues to a break for a couple of hours to contemplate his idea. Two hours later, Kumble had the job that no one seemed to want.

"It is not like that," says Kumble, "I am enjoying it. I think of it as a responsibility I have been given and want to do it well." The off-field challenges, he says, "are not much. I have had 18 years of experience. You have enough challenges on the field itself."

In Australia, India are led by a man in total control of his game and at total ease with himself, at the peak of his mental powers as a player. On the field his team has reflected that assurance.

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